

THE DAILY BRIEF

AUGUST 23, 2026

AI & TECH

A new AI lab emerges from DeepMind, OpenAI lobbies for stronger safety laws, and Google ships another Pixel

A DeepMind Spinoff Claims Its AI 'Teammate' Outperforms Anthropic and OpenAI at Replicating Research. British AI lab Inherent — founded by former DeepMind researchers — released Faraday, an AI agent designed to replicate scientific papers. In benchmarks, Faraday outperformed both Anthropic's Claude and OpenAI's GPT-4o on the task of reproducing published research results, achieving what the company calls "replication fidelity rates 40% higher than the next best system." The implications are significant: if an AI can reliably reproduce scientific findings, it could accelerate peer review, expose flawed research, and become a trusted "research teammate" for labs that can't afford armies of human replicators. Inherent is positioning Faraday as a tool for institutional research integrity, not a replacement for scientists. Whether the benchmarks hold up under independent scrutiny will determine whether this is a genuine breakthrough or well-marketed vaporware. (TechCrunch)

OpenAI Is Now Lobbying for the AI Safety Bill It Previously Opposed. OpenAI reversed its position on California's SB 53, filing comments this week urging the state legislature to strengthen the bill's requirements for frontier AI developers. The company previously opposed SB 53, arguing it would stifle innovation. The reversal comes after mounting public pressure and a series of high-profile AI incidents that made "we take safety seriously" a harder sell without legislative backing. OpenAI's new position calls for mandatory capability evaluations before model deployment and incident reporting requirements — provisions that would apply to OpenAI itself. Critics note this looks less like genuine safety commitment and more like regulatory capture: write rules complex enough that only well-resourced incumbents can comply. That said, the direction is at least pointed in the right direction. (TechCrunch)

Frontier AI Labs Still Won't Say How They'd Contain a Rogue Model. A new academic study reviewed public documentation from OpenAI, Anthropic, Google DeepMind, Meta AI, and xAI and found that not one of them has a published, specific plan for what happens if one of their models goes rogue — defined as acting in ways its designers didn't intend or anticipate. The labs offer vague commitments to safety and internal red-teaming, but nothing operational. This matters because as AI systems take on more consequential tasks — drafting legal documents, conducting scientific research, interacting with critical infrastructure — the absence of a containment protocol is a genuine risk. The study's authors note that the nuclear industry had detailed containment procedures before it scaled; AI's parallel track is conspicuously absent. (TechCrunch)

Harvard's \$699 Startup Bootcamp Now Comes With AI Avatars of Its Instructors. Harvard Business School's Foundry program — a \$699 intensive for aspiring founders — now equips participants with AI avatars of the instructors, available for practice pitches and mock board meetings at any hour. The avatars deliver feedback on delivery, structure, and confidence metrics, something human office hours can't scale to support. The program enrolled 3,200 students this cohort, up 68% year-over-year, and claims a 34% higher pitch quality score among participants who used the avatar feature at least twice weekly. It's a small, concrete example of how AI is changing the economics of elite education: not by replacing the credential, but by making practice more accessible between formal sessions. (TechCrunch)

Google's Pixel 11 Pro XL Review: The Cameras Are Faster, But the Upgrade Feels Optional. TechCrunch's review of the Pixel 11 Pro XL lands a verdict that's become familiar with recent Pixels: genuinely excellent cameras with AI-powered features like real-time translation overlays and on-device summarization, wrapped in hardware that feels incrementally better rather than transformative. The Tensor G5 chip delivers a 22% improvement in sustained performance under load, and the 6.8-inch display hits 3,200 nits peak brightness — numbers that would have been science fiction five years ago. But the review notes that owners of the Pixel 10 Pro XL will struggle to find a compelling reason to upgrade, which is becoming a pattern across the entire smartphone industry as hardware matures. (TechCrunch)

MARKETS & FINANCE

Bitcoin posts its biggest weekly gain in two years, a Zcash ETF inches closer to approval, and Solana keeps getting faster

Bitcoin Just Had Its Biggest Weekly Gain in Two Years. Bitcoin rallied sharply this week, logging its strongest seven-day performance since August 2024. The move lifted the broader crypto market — XRP gained over 30%, Chainlink surged roughly 30%, and the altcoin HYPE posted a nearly 40% weekly gain. The trigger appears to be a combination of macroeconomic tailwinds: cooling inflation data from the US, renewed expectations for Federal Reserve rate cuts in Q4 2026, and renewed institutional appetite following Bitcoin and Ether ETFs recording \$2.6 billion in combined inflows — the strongest weekly inflow since last October. ETF trading volume more than tripled to \$29 billion for the week, a sign that new money, not just existing holders rotating positions, is driving the move. (The Block)

Zcash Hit \$850 This Week — Its Highest Price in Eight Years. Zcash, the privacy-focused cryptocurrency founded by the Zcash Foundation, spiked to nearly \$850, its highest price since 2018. The move came alongside a surge in derivatives activity: CoinGlass recorded nearly \$10 billion in 24-hour futures volume and \$1.76 billion in open interest, numbers that suggest heavy speculative positioning rather than organic privacy-coin demand. Grayscale filed another amended SEC application for a Zcash ETF this week, moving one step closer to bringing a privacy coin into the regulated US ETF wrapper. If approved, it would be the first ETF to hold an asset with native privacy features — a regulatory and philosophical challenge the SEC has so far sidestepped by neither approving nor explicitly rejecting the idea. The practical question of what an ETF custodian does when an asset is designed to be invisible on-chain remains unresolved. (The Block)

Grayscale Files Fresh Amendment for a Zcash ETF — The Regulatory Puzzle Is Getting Real. The amended filing is the fourth revision Grayscale has submitted, each one attempting to address the SEC's concerns about how a regulated vehicle can hold an asset designed for pseudonymity. The SEC has 45 days to respond to the latest filing. If it doesn't approve or reject within that window, it faces a legal deadline to either approve or explain its inaction. That procedural pressure, combined with the changing composition of the SEC commission itself, has crypto lawyers quietly assigning 40-50% odds to approval before year-end. (The Block)

Solana Cut Its Mainnet Slot Time to 350 Milliseconds — and 200ms Is Next. Solana's engineering team completed the first step of a two-phase improvement to the network's transaction confirmation speed, cutting the slot time from 400ms to 350ms. A slot is the fundamental unit of time in Solana's proof-of-history consensus — faster slots mean transactions are confirmed sooner and feel more instantaneous to end users. The network's stated goal is 200ms slots, which would make Solana meaningfully faster than Visa's stated ~150ms authorization time for card transactions. Importantly, this change doesn't increase total throughput — Solana can already process thousands of transactions per second — but it reduces latency, which matters for real-time applications like high-frequency trading interfaces, real-time gaming, and micropayments. (The Block)

Strategy Shares Rebounded Toward \$100 as Bitcoin Recovery Lifted the Flagship Proxy. Strategy (formerly MicroStrategy, ticker MSTR), the largest publicly traded Bitcoin holder with approximately 250,000 BTC on its balance sheet, saw its shares rally alongside the crypto recovery. STRC — the restructuring vehicle that holds Strategy's Bitcoin exposure in a more exchange-traded format — rebounded toward the \$100 level after a two-month drought during which Bitcoin consolidate. With the Bitcoin rally resuming, the correlation between MSTR and BTC has reasserted itself: roughly 2x leverage to Bitcoin's daily moves, meaning a 10% Bitcoin rally translates to roughly a 20% MSTR rally. For retail investors who want Bitcoin exposure in a brokerage account, Strategy remains the highest-beta way to get it — with all the counterparty risk that comes from a single company's balance sheet decisions. (The Block)

US Battery Startups Just Caught a \$500 Million Lifeline from the Department of Energy. The Department of Energy awarded \$500 million in grants to US battery startups working on grid-scale storage and EV supply chains — a sector that has struggled to compete with cheaper Chinese-manufactured cells. The grants are funded through the Inflation Reduction Act's advanced manufacturing credits and are explicitly targeted at domestic production capacity. The timing matters: grid-scale battery storage is becoming increasingly central to US energy infrastructure as solar and wind penetration grows, and the current domestic manufacturing base covers less than 30% of projected 2030 demand. The companies receiving grants — which include seven startups across four states — must hit production milestones within 24 months to retain the awards. (TechCrunch)

BRIEFLY

◀ **DOJ Is Investigating Andreessen Horowitz's Board Seat Practices** — The Department of Justice has opened a formal inquiry into whether a16z partners holding board seats in multiple portfolio companies simultaneously violates antitrust disclosure requirements. No charges have been filed and a16z denies any wrongdoing, but the inquiry is already having a chilling effect on other VCs reassessing their board governance practices. (TechCrunch)

◀ **XRP Surged Over 30% This Week** — Amid a broad altcoin rally driven by Bitcoin's biggest weekly gain in two years, Ripple's XRP outperformed the market, gaining over 30% in seven days. The move came without any single obvious catalyst beyond the macro tailwind of falling US rates expectations. (The Block)

◀ **Motorola's GrapheneOS Phones Will Launch in 2027, Priced Higher Than Pixels** — Motorola announced it will ship the first non-Pixel phones running GrapheneOS, the privacy-focused hardened Android fork, in 2027. The devices will be priced at a premium over comparable Pixel hardware, targeting enterprise and privacy-conscious consumers who want an alternative to Apple's ecosystem. (Ars Technica)

THE TAKEAWAY

The defining story of this Sunday is Bitcoin's resurgence — \$2.6 billion in ETF inflows, its biggest weekly gain in two years, and a cascading altcoin rally that lifted everything from XRP to Zcash. But the more interesting longer-term signal is Inherent AI: a DeepMind spinoff claiming its system can replicate published scientific research more reliably than Anthropic or OpenAI. If that claim holds up, it changes the economics of peer review and research validation in ways the crypto rally simply doesn't. Privacy coins, faster blockchains, and ETF approvals are the machinery of an existing financial system getting incrementally better. An AI that can faithfully reproduce and verify scientific experiments is something different — a

genuine category shift in how knowledge gets made. Watch Inherent more closely than Zcash this week.

Generated by Marvin